Scared to Death

by Doug McConnaha



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The first time I remember being really scared was the summer when I was seven years old. My older sister and I had decided to camp out in the back yard in a tent. My folks came out and tucked us in. My dad stayed long enough to tell us a scary story about a ghost with an axe who wandered around looking for his head. Dad was holding the flashlight under his face as he told us how the ghost would chop off heads and try them on to see if they fit.

I knew that dad made the story up, and that there wasn't really a ghost. He even finished up classic line, "and to this day, the ghost wanders around, looking for his head." Then he did his best scary face and said in a creepy voice, "Goodnight, pleasant dreams." And then he turned off the flashlight and went inside. My sister and I were scrunched way down in our sleeping bags, giggling and being silly.

After a few minutes though, my sister was asleep. There I was in the tent, alone and wide-awake. I don't know how long I lay there before I realized that something was outside the tent. At first, I thought that I was just hearing the wind, or a cat, but then I heard a definite thump, like something hitting the ground. I didn't move at first. I just froze and listened. Every few seconds I would hear the thump, and it was getting closer to the tent. I tried to wake my sister up, but she was sound asleep. I pushed on her and pushed, but she just kept sleeping. I was really scared by now, and starting to cry. I knew that if I was too loud, then whatever was outside the tent would hear me. I lay there in that dark tent, perfectly still. My muscles were aching from trying not to move or even breathe.

After what seemed like forever, I turned my head slowly and looked at the shadowy shapes on the side of the tent. Then, one of the shadows moved. Not like a dog or cat, but like someone who was squatting down low, trying to be hidden.

I took a deep breath and let out a scream that I didn't expect. I screamed and screamed and screamed. My sister woke up, screaming at the top of her lungs. There we were, two scared little girls, screaming as loud as we could. Me screaming because there was something outside the tent moving, and my sister screaming because there was someone inside the tent screaming.

My mom came running out the door with a flashlight, and she was screaming loudest of all. She shined her flashlight on the moving shadow, just in time to catch my dad, creeping towards us with a Halloween mask on.

Needless to say, nobody thought that it was very funny, least of all my mother. She hauled us inside and put my sister and I in our own beds. Mom and dad had an awful fight. Mom yelled at dad, called him "stupid and cruel," said that she couldn't believe that he would do something like that.

Dad yelled back, told her that she was overprotective and didn't have a sense of humor. He said that just because his grown-up wife was afraid of the dark that his daughters didn't have to be.

I heard my mother slap my father. I actually heard the sound of her hand striking his face, hard. Silence followed. Then I saw him move past my door; go down the hall and outside. I thought that he was going out to get the tent or our stuff we left out there. Instead, he got into his car and tore out of the driveway.

Mom was in tears and my sister was crying over on her side of the room. I knew that mom and dad had argued before, but I never heard a fight as bad as this.

Dad didn't come home that night. I found out later that he spent the night in his car in a parking lot. He walked into the house as we were sitting down to a very quiet breakfast. He looked terrible. His face was all dirty and his eyes were red. Like he had been crying.

He came into the kitchen, got down on his knees, scooped my sister and me into his arms and kept saying "I'm sorry, I'm so sorry," over and over. My mom came around the table and put her arms around all of us and we all cried together. My dad promised never to scare us again, and he never did.

And none of us ever talked about that night until now.

But I've always been afraid of the dark since that night.

As a teenager, I began to have strange dreams. Sometimes I would dream that I had an axe, and that I was wandering around looking for a victim. In other dreams, I would be running from a figure that was chasing me, and I would trip over something, look down and see my own head on the ground. That dream would wake me up, shaking, and I could never get back to sleep after that one.

The dreams tapered off in college, and I soon forgot all about them. Then, I met Peter. We were married right out of college. He was so good to me at first, but he had a temper that I began to fear. That fear must have tapped something in my memories – maybe it was the way Peter would laugh after playing one of his cruel jokes on me; I don't know.

But, I do know that the dreams started again. Some nights I would take a couple of sleeping pills just to get back to sleep after a nightmare. Then, two weeks ago, on Halloween, Peter decided to play one of his... his little jokes on me. First, he took me to the movies and made me watch one of those horrible stories about a deranged killer with a knife who was chasing teenagers.

Every time I would turn my face away from the screen, he would put his hand on the back of my neck, and force me to look. He leaned over and whispered, "Come on, don't be such a chicken. It's only a movie."

That night, I couldn't sleep; actually, I was afraid to close my eyes. I knew the nightmares would come, and I was so scared. Peter was getting angrier with me for not turning off my bedside lamp, and I was on the edge of tears. Desperate, I took four sleeping pills and tried to go to sleep, but not to dream.

It didn't work. I remember the dream so vividly. I remember dreaming that I was in the house, in bed, but that there was something in the room with me. I remember getting out of bed to turn on a light, but the lights wouldn't work. The only light was coming from the strange glow around the window. I felt my way along the wall in the dark, and my foot kicked something on the floor.

I knew what I would see if I looked down! I knew I'd see my head with an axe on the floor next to it!! I forced myself from somewhere inside my conscious mind to say, "This is just a dream." But I couldn't stop myself from looking down. Slowly, I looked at what I had kicked in my dream, and then I froze. On the floor was an axe, but it was Peter's head next to it! I stepped back, and the eyes opened and Peter's mouth moved. That head on the floor said, "Come on, it's only a dream." I screamed and picked up the axe and began hitting the head, harder and harder. It kept changing from Peter's face to a Halloween mask and back to Peter.

Finally, I woke up. I woke up to find myself standing over my bed, holding a hammer, covered in blood. Peter was laying there, dead. I screamed and screamed and screamed, and finally, the police came. My nightmares have come true.

(*Loud sobbing that slowly turns into laughter.)*

How was that? Do you think the jury will buy that story? That's right, the poor, little girl who was traumatized as a child can't be blamed for turning into the poor adult who killed her no-good husband.

The jury will eat it up.